shipped out to Camp Lee, Virginia, where Mel Roberts had been. It was just outside Petersburg, Virginia, twenty-five miles south of Richmond and three hundred miles south of New York City.

In Camp Lee, I was put in the 62nd Quartermaster Training Company, and the next day I was on KP again. I came across a German prisoner of war and spoke German to him, while a crowd of youngsters gathered around and listened in amazement, since they had never heard anyone speak anything but English before. I also saw, for the first time in my life, an illiterate adult. Someone was writing a letter for him.

As for me, I wrote letters constantly—to Meisel, to Machlowitz, to Campbell, to Heinlein, to de Camp, to Stanley, to my parents, and so on. And, of course, I wrote a letter daily to Gertrude (except when it was physically impossible, which was rare).

My letters to Gertrude told her of daily events that I did my best to make funny—as much to cheer myself as to cheer her. They were a better record of my Army life in many ways, I suppose, than my diary was. 1

Gertrude, alas, did not answer daily. She was quite busy at the Henry Paper Box Company (it was her candy store, I guess) and, in any case, no one in her family was much of a letter writer.

She wrote me about once a week during my stay in the Army, and they were valued letters indeed. They dealt chiefly with events at the Henry Paper Box Company, where things, apparently, went from one crisis to another. There were always frictions with the employees who were, according to Gertrude's account, very difficult and, in some cases, psychotic. There was also trouble with the union, with the landlord, and with the suppliers.

I was tempted to point out that these problems were characteristic of the life of the small entrepreneur attempting to start a family business with insufficient capital—something I had tried to warn them

1 1 kept my diary carefully throughout my stay in the Army. By this time I was in my eighth volume, and not to keep it up to date had become unthinkable.

against at the start. (I might be an unworldly person, but I did have the kind of experience that came with watching a candy store being run.) It had done no good.